

VICINO. Generative expressions of proximity, rhythm, and unspoken connections

Bin Cheng

Southern University of Science and Technology
Shenzhen, China
12111920@mail.sustech.edu.cn

Haoran Rui

Southern University of Science and Technology
Shenzhen, China
1344123783@qq.com

Zi Ye

Southern University of Science and Technology
Shenzhen, China
yezilucy0606@gmail.com

Mirna Zordan*

Southern University of Science and Technology
Shenzhen, China
mzordan@sustech.edu.cn

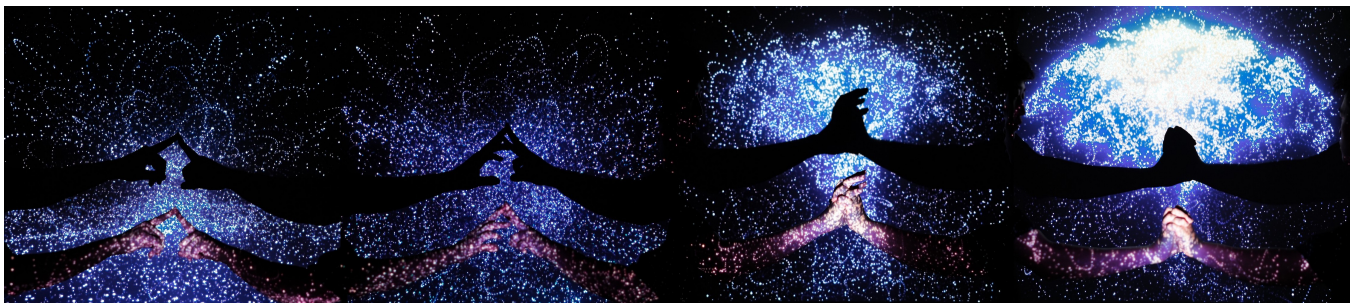


Figure 1: VICINO: interaction flow. Two participants' contact is detected and visualized as a branching tree that grows, stabilizes, pulses, and eventually dissolves

Abstract

VICINO (Italian for “close to”) investigates the fading role of human contact in an age of constant communication yet rare connection. Inspired by the neuroscience of affective touch, the work offers a space where interpersonal connection is made perceptible again through embodied interaction. As participants hold hands while the other hand remains grounded on conductive surfaces, the system captures nuanced bioelectrical signals coming from their hearts. Each moment of sustained contact triggers the growth of a visual tree, with branches and heartbeat-linked pulses blooming in shared silence. Neither a spectacle nor a tool, VICINO becomes a quiet interface for sensing one another’s presence outside verbal expression. The project emphasizes the poetic and relational potential of human proximity, turning bodily gestures into visual languages of empathy and resonance. It encourages audiences to slow down, reach out, and reimagine how connection can be felt in invisible, physiological ways.

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*Corresponding author.

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1 Description of Artwork

VICINO is an interactive installation that transforms human contact into an evolving audiovisual landscape. The system is built around a bio-electrical loop: participants each place one hand on a grounded conductive surface, while using the other to engage in physical contact. As hands are holding, the system captures duration and surface area of contact via capacitive sensors, gradually generating a dynamic visual structure resembling a tree, which blooms and grows in response to sustained interaction.

The installation captures heart rate data through photoplethysmography (PPG) sensors, which subtly alter visual feedback in real time. When participants reach a phase of calmness and coordinated interaction, the visual environment begins to pulse gently with their rhythms, reinforcing a sense of co-regulation and physiological connection.

VICINO combines Playtronica TouchMe, PPG sensors, and a TouchDesigner. The design intentionally avoids clear cause-effect mappings between user actions and system response, encouraging participants to engage with each other rather than the system itself.

Through its bio-electrical loop translated into a minimal yet affective aesthetic, VICINO creates a ritualistic space for slowness, attunement, and silent negotiation of agency between bodies.